FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE:
ANNOUNCING THE FORMATION OF SOMETHING STUPID 501(c)(3) dba LADDS 500

The original rules for The Ladds 500 stated “We are allowed to be in the park, and we are allowed to ride in the road.” Implicit in these statements is the awareness that while it didn’t feel like what we were doing required permission from anyone; I suspected that this might not be a universally shared understanding.

The 500 was held four times under this premise. During the leadup to the Fourth First Annual edition I called the Parks Department to see if they might be willing to place some temporary sanitation facilities in the park for the day. My statement to the effect of “it’s not really an event, more like a group of friends getting together for the day” raised more questions than it answered. While Parks did oblige my request, they also wrote the sentence “The Ladds 500 sounds like a great community activity, but you will be required to obtain a permit next year per City Code.”

Permission comes with liability, and faced with a blank space marked “Organization” on a permitting form I reached out to Umbrella 501(c)(3) for help. It was through this partnership that I learned about the legal mechanism of Fiscal Sponsorship, in which a project is able to use the legal non-profit entity status of a parent organization. This created a degree of separation between myself as an individual and the event, and allowed fundraising to happen in a formal way without requiring me to create an entire administrative superstructure from scratch — at a time when I was not entirely confident that the event would be able to afford itself with the added fiscal pressures of permits, ever-scaling infrastructure requirements, insurance, and the fees associated with the fiscal sponsorship agreement.

The first permitted edition of The Ladds 500 was originally scheduled for April of 2020, but ended up taking place in 2022. With the running of The Ninth First Annual for the Ten Year Anniversary in April of 2026, The Ladds 500 has happened more often with permission than it ever did without. For the past two years, I have been able to both permit and, critically, insure an actual (as opposed to a de facto) road closure; something which had not previously seemed possible.

With eyes looking forward to the Tenth First Annual Ladds 500, to take place on the Saturday after the second Friday in April 2027, I am excited to formally announce the formation of Something Stupid 501(c)(3). I am serving as Chair of the Board and will continue to act as the event’s Executive Director for the foreseeable future. From the perspective of participants nothing will change. Bringing administration of the event fully under its own auspices will simplify several under-the-hood processes and allow me to sharpen my focus on The 500 specifically and free fun in public more generally.

Thank you to Umbrella for their guidance over the past several years, to the donors big and small who have helped ensure the fiscal sustainability of the event as it has grown, to all participants of the Nine First Annual editions, and to the board of Something Stupid who support me in my efforts to keep this thing going.

I’ll see you next Spring, let’s do Something Stupid™.



-David Barstow Robinson
Founder & Executive Director, The Ladds 500
Chair of the Board, Something Stupid 501(c)(3)